

Custard-filled doughnuts

Bolas de Berlim

Makes about 12

3 eggs
 Finely grated zest of 2 oranges
 3½ cups/500 g all-purpose flour
 ⅔ cup/130 g superfine sugar
 1 teaspoon fine sea salt
 ¼ ounce/25 g fresh yeast, or
 ¾ ounce/12 g active dry yeast
 ½ cup/110 g butter, cut into cubes
 and softened

For the egg cream filling

⅞ cup/200 ml sugar syrup (page 33)
 6 egg yolks
 Finely grated zest of 1 lemon
 1½ ounces/40 g ground almonds

Vegetable oil, for frying
 Superfine sugar, for dusting

Bolas de Berlim literally means “balls from Berlin,” and these were first brought to Portugal by Jewish refugees. We had to make them our own, of course, so some crafty genius decided to slit the doughnut open and fill it with egg custard. I love the yeasty flavor of the soft dough, the sugary crust, and the creamy filling. Get creative when you make these yourself: you can use plain old jam, Nutella, or whipped cream as a filling—or you could even create a savory doughnut like my favorite, crab and crème fraîche, using exactly the same dough recipe.

Mix the eggs, ½ cup/130 ml of water, and the orange zest in a bowl and refrigerate for 2 hours before using.

Combine the flour, sugar, and salt in the bowl of a stand mixer using the paddle attachment. Whisk the yeast into the egg and water mixture, pour it into the mixer bowl, and then mix for 20 minutes, or until the dough is smooth and comes away from the sides of the bowl. Add the butter gradually, mixing until it is fully incorporated and the dough is smooth and stretchy. Put the dough in a lightly oiled bowl, cover it loosely with plastic wrap, and leave it in the fridge to rise overnight.

To make the filling — Heat the sugar syrup in a pan until it is just boiling, then leave to cool for a few minutes. Whisk the egg yolks lightly in a heatproof bowl, then pour the sugar syrup over them, whisking constantly. Pour the mixture back into the pan and cook gently over low heat for 10 to 12 minutes, or until thickened, stirring constantly. Remove from the heat and stir in the lemon zest and ground almonds. Pour onto a plate and leave to cool to room temperature, covered with plastic wrap to prevent a skin from forming.

To shape the doughnuts, divide the dough into 12 roughly 1½-ounce/40 g pieces and shape each piece into a small ball with your hands. Cover them with a tea towel and leave to rise for 30 minutes, or until doubled in size.

Fill a large, heavy-bottomed pan one-third full with oil and heat it to 355°F/180°C, or until a cube of bread sizzles and turns

golden brown almost immediately. Fry the doughnuts in batches for about 2 minutes, or until golden brown. Remove, drain on paper towels, and roll in superfine sugar while warm, then leave them to cool.

Make a slit in the middle of each doughnut without cutting all the way through. Spoon the egg cream filling inside and serve immediately.

